CYCLISTIC

Converting Casuals into Members

A behavioral analysis of 5.5M Chicago bike-share trips

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The growth lever is conversion, not acquisition.

Casual riders and members are two fundamentally different customers. Casuals ride for leisure — longer trips, weekends, summer. Members commute. Closing this behavioral gap, not chasing new users, is the highest-ROI path to growth.

5.5M

TRIP RECORDS ANALYZED

across both rider segments

87%

RIDE-LENGTH GAP

casuals (23.5 min) vs members (12.6 min)

14×

SEASONAL VOLUME SWING

casual rides: January vs August

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Why conversion beats acquisition

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Testing plan and measurement

5.5M trips. Two stories.

01

SECTION

The Business Problem

Future growth depends on converting casual riders — not acquiring new ones.

Conversion over acquisition

THE CONTEXT

Cyclistic's long-term growth strategy focuses on converting existing casual riders into annual members — a more efficient path than broad new-user acquisition.

WHY IT MATTERS

Members generate recurring revenue and operational predictability. Casual riders already use the service — they're pre-qualified leads who simply haven't committed.

THE CORE QUESTION

How can we identify and target casual riders whose behavior already aligns with the value of annual membership?

The answer lies in behavior — not demographics.

How we analyzed 5.5M trips

01

DATA

5.5M trip records from Motivate Intl. via the City of Chicago — start/end times, stations, rider type.

02

CLEAN

Removed invalid ride durations. Engineered features: ride length, day of week, hour of day.

03

ANALYZE

SQL aggregations in BigQuery. Python (Pandas, Seaborn) for segmentation and statistical analysis.

04

VISUALIZE

Interactive Power BI dashboard for stakeholder exploration with dynamic day/month filters.

TOOLSTACK **Excel · SQL (BigQuery) · Python (Pandas, Seaborn, Matplotlib) · Power BI**

03

SECTION

Behavioral Insights

Four findings that reframe the conversion strategy.

INSIGHT 01

Members ride to commute. Casuals ride for leisure.

AVERAGE RIDE DURATION

CASUAL

23.5

minutes

longer trips · weekend-heavy

MEMBER

12.6

minutes

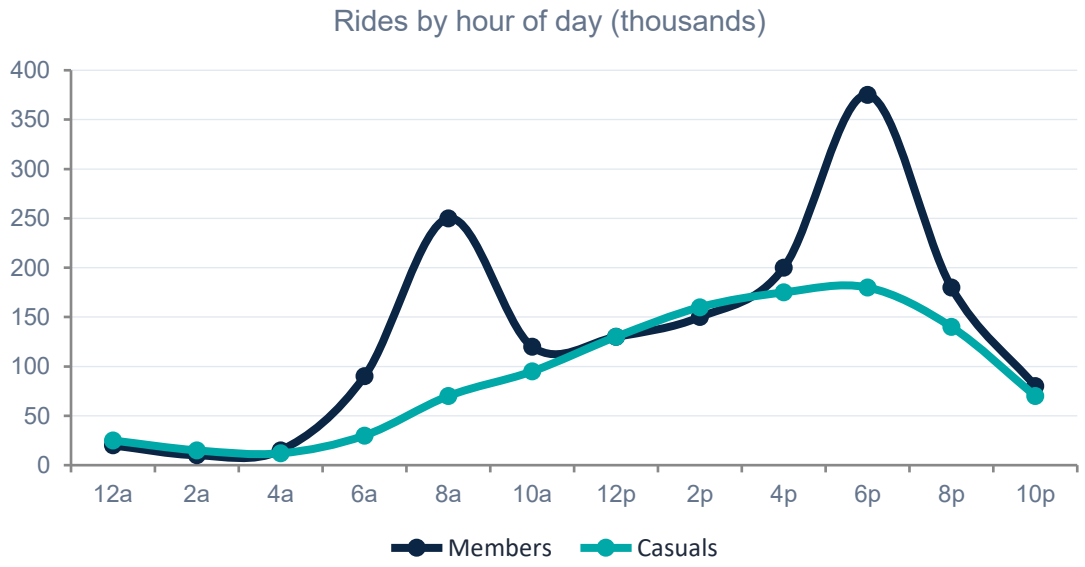
shorter trips · weekday commutes

AN 87% GAP

Two fundamentally different use cases.

This isn't a duration preference — it's a use-case divide. Casuals take the bike for leisure and errands; members use it as transportation infrastructure. Messaging built for one will miss the other entirely.

The commute signature is unmistakable.



MEMBERS

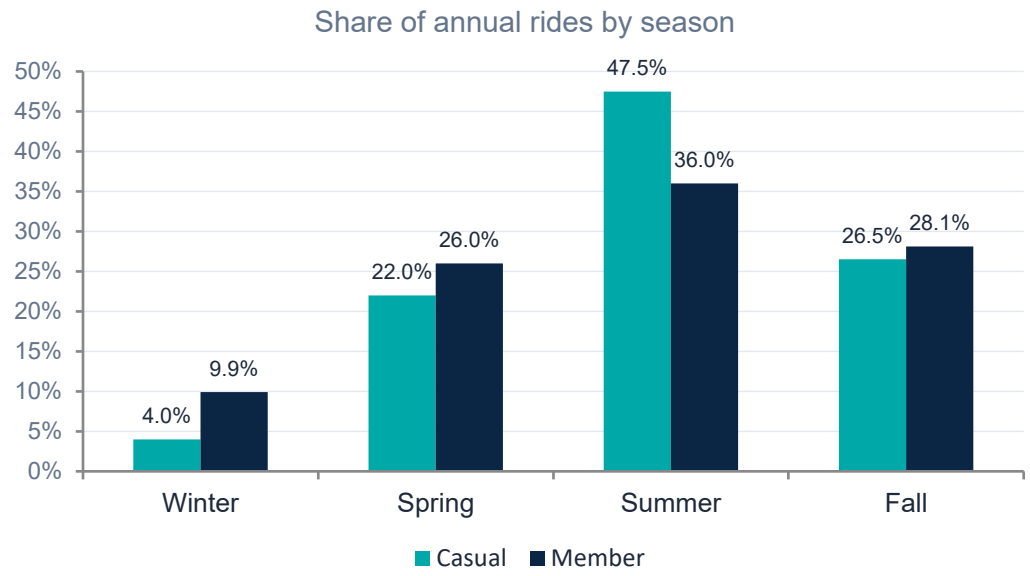
Two sharp peaks — 8 AM and 5 PM. A textbook commute pattern tied to the work day.

CASUALS

No commute behavior at all — a gradual build into a flat afternoon plateau. Errands, tourism, leisure.

Implication: conversion messaging cannot be one-size-fits-all.

Seasonality exposes the window.



CASUALS

47.5%

of casual rides happen in summer. Just 4% happen in winter.

THE WINDOW

14×

Casual volume swing between January and August — vs. 4× for members.

Late spring through summer is the highest-ROI window for conversion campaigns.

INSIGHT 04

The membership product is built for the wrong customer.

CURRENT PRODUCT

Built for the commuter.

- Weekday-frequency pricing model
- Messaging around daily transportation
- Short-trip value proposition
- Year-round commitment structure

OBSERVED BEHAVIOR

Driven by leisure.

- Weekend usage spikes
- Longer rides, tourism and errands
- Seasonal engagement (summer-heavy)
- Low commitment to year-round commuting

THE IMPLICATION

Closing the gap requires a redesigned value proposition — pricing, messaging, and structure aligned with leisure use, not forced commute assumptions.

Where to focus, when to launch, who to target.

01

TARGET HIGH-FREQUENCY WEEKDAY CASUALS

Their behavior already resembles members. Lowest friction, highest conversion likelihood — start here.

02

LAUNCH SEASONAL CAMPAIGNS IN LATE SPRING AND SUMMER

Maximum surface area: the casual rider pool is largest and most engaged during these months.

03

POSITION MEMBERSHIP AROUND COST SAVINGS

For recurring-usage riders, reframe membership as a financial win — not a lifestyle commitment.

04

INTRODUCE LIMITED-TIME TRIAL MEMBERSHIPS

Reduce commitment friction for frequent casual users. Let behavior finish the sale.

From insight to impact.

DEFINE
Set criteria for high-frequency casuals — ride count, duration, and weekday patterns.

COHORT
Track rider cohorts over time to identify consistent usage and conversion readiness.

A / B TEST
Run targeted membership offers on identified segments; measure conversion lift.

ITERATE
Monitor campaign performance; refine targeting based on observed behavior.

THANK YOU.

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Questions & discussion welcome.